In those days, the dogs were mainly used for hunting and for protection from wild animals. Latur district was once a haven for wildlife, with a large population of tigers—inevitably regarded as a menace by the local cattle warders. The Pashmis and Caravans were apparently regarded as a godsend by the villagers at the time. Legend has it that their unbridled aggression could keep even tigers at bay.

But all this was local lore and practice. The Pashmi and the Caravan caught the eyes of dog lovers in a rural dog show organised by the Hyderabad-based Ethnic Indica Canine Society, which encourages Indian breeds, at Janwal in 2002. The Pashmis were the stars of the show. Ever since then, the Pashmis have been a firm favourite.

THREAT TO RARE BREEDS

However, ominous dark clouds hover over the scene. The government's apathy and the villagers' quest for more money have put the breeds in danger of extinction, say experts. Pramod Salunkhe, a dog breeder and former president of the Latur Canine Club, says inbreeding—over-reliance on a few prized studs like Pawar's Malhar—has caused the quality of these dogs to dip. "The Caravan is known for hunting. However, the villagers promoted Punjab Greyhounds (often reared for racing) over Caravans as they are faster," he says. "If not taken care of, the Pashmi and the Caravan breeds will soon become extinct."

The villagers also do not maintain a record of those buying their dogs, so there is no reliable database on which to establish pedigree. The Chennai-based Kennel Club of India (KCI) maintains records of each of the indigenous breeds. The KCI panel judges several breeds of dogs and issues certificates, authenticating their genuineness and importance. "We are trying for a certificate for the Pashmi and the Caravan from KCI. That will help us in branding them in a more efficient way," says Salunkhe.

Under then chief minister Vilasrao Deshmukh, who represented Latur in the Maharashtra assembly, the government had allotted a two-acre plot on the outskirts of Latur city for setting up a breeding centre for Pashmis and Caravans in 2008. It never came up. "There is a need for scientific research and adoption of ways to preserve these rare breeds. Their reducing numbers are our collective failure," says Salunkhe.

Finally, wisdom dawned in 2020, when the Maharashtra government initiated a genetic study of native species of cattle and domesticated animals in the Marathwada region, which includes Latur. The idea was to study the genetic traits of Pashmis and Caravans, Osmanabad goats, Red Kandhari cows and Deoni bulls. Unfortunately, the project now seems to be foundering because of inadequate funding.

Maintaining the 'quality' of the Pashmi breed worries Tanaji Pawar too, but only to the extent of his immediate needs. Pawar has to identify a quality male Pashmi once Malhar gets older, to keep his profitable breeding business going. "It is nine years old now, but I need to plan for the future. There are very few male Pashmis left in the village," he says. It will let loose the dogs of war of a different kind. ■

TOP DOG



PASHMI: Its name originates from 'Pashtun', inhabitants of Afghanistan. The hairy breed has been in the Deccan for over a century. Intelligent and loyal, a Pashmi can even take on a wild boar.



CARAVAN: With its tucked waist and deep chest, this slender dog is a favourite of hunters. It can outpace a Chinkara deer and is faster than a German Shepherd.



SALUKI: It is considered an upgraded version of the Caravan, also known as the Persian Greyhound. Villagers in Latur and Osmanabad have developed a fondness for Salukis in recent years.